at SonyLIV, when asked about their linguistic expansion. SonyLIV unveils its southside line-up with *Meme Boys* (Tamil). Telugu, Malayalam and Kannada are next on the radar.

LANGUAGE NO BAR

Why only now? "Everybody first wanted to get Hindi right," says aha's Thakur. "It's a big battleground, it is expensive and it has occupied all the mind space." Having developed hundreds of series in Hindi for five years now, OTT platforms are keen to collaborate with filmmakers in the robust Chennai and Hyderabad entertainment industries. Some like Aparna Purohit, head of originals at Amazon Prime Video, were visiting these two cities as far back as in 2017-18, meeting filmmakers like Pushkar-Gayathri (of *Vikram Vedha* fame), Pa Ranjith (*Madras*, *Kabali*), Sudha Kongara (*Irudhi Suttru*), among others. "Every time the licensing team struck a deal, I'd be like 'Please introduce me to the creator'," recalls Purohit. "Initially, they [creators] were sussing us out. They wanted to know 'Is there commitment? Are we serious about it?' On one such trip, when Pushkar-Gayathri floated the idea of a police investigation that unfolds in the backdrop of a local festival, Purohit "knew it would transcend" linguistic and geographical barriers.

COMING SOON...



↘ MAA NEELLA TANK [ZEE5]

Set in a small village in Nellore district, the Telugu romcom starts off when a wannabe influencer threatens to do a Veeru and jump off a water tank if he doesn't get to marry the woman he wants. A police officer reluctantly intervenes.



↘ TAMILROCKERZ [SONYLIV]

A police officer fights against time and unruly fans as he looks to stop the notorious piracy group from leaking a big-budgeted and highly anticipated film

AFTER GETTING HINDI RIGHT BY MAKING HUNDREDS OF SERIES IN THE PAST FIVE YEARS, OTT PLATFORMS ARE KEEN TO WORK WITH FILMMAKERS IN THE ROBUST CHENNAI AND HYDERABAD INDUSTRIES

The Covid-19 pandemic helped bridge these boundaries further. As cinemas had to down shutters for months, the likes of Amazon Prime Video, Netflix and SonyLIV acquired an abundance of southern films and added to their library and audience base. The EY-FICCI report noted that 50 per cent of the viewers of regional language films on OTT platforms in 2021 came from outside the home state. "In the past two years, the linguistic palette has expanded and accessibility has increased so much," says Purohit, adding that an average Amazon Prime Video user watches content in four languages. Even as Purohit feels "accepted and embraced" by the southern film fraternity, she knows the significance of having "local boots on the ground". She has what she describes as a "skeletal but well-networked team who speak and understand the language". Amazon Prime Video's southern roster includes instalments of *Modern Love Hyderabad* and *Modern Love: Chennai*, *Dhootha* with Telugu actor Naga Chaitanya and the Tamil series *The Village* with Arya.

GOING GLOBAL WITH LOCAL

With the OTT viewer warming up to language-agnostic content, more content producers have been motivated to take the southern market seriously. Chennai-based Suji Prabhakaran, chief cluster officer – south (linear and OTT) at ZEE Entertainment Enterprises Ltd, spent the last year and a half developing originals in the south. "We started looking for strong stories rooted in our culture," he says. Soon, Prabhakaran and even aha's Thakur realised the need "to build the muscle of series